

Epochal

She wakes up in warmth. She doesn't remember much, but there wasn't anything to remember in the first place; only darkness and a deep and terrible chill that rattles her bones as she lays there, staring at the objects spinning above her.

She begins to cry.

A hum floats from the hallway into the room, reaching into the crib she lies in and soothing her ears.

"Oh, Emma, what's the matter?" the voice says. A woman enters the room, her face framed by wild, curly hair, with her arms outstretched. She grabs her from the crib and holds her to her chest, bouncing them both up and down. "You wake up grumpy, honey?" the woman says, her voice thick with sugar.

Emma's cries peter out as she becomes entranced with the woman. She is sunlight and stardust; a familiar feeling Emma can't quite place. They bounce in the nursery until Emma's head falls against the woman's chest, gentle snoring parting her lips.

Emma lived her life here in this house with this woman, who later became *Mom*, playing soccer, dirtying brand-new shoes with mud in the creek, and learning the art of photography. She left for college, returned for when her mother began dying, and stayed well after her mother passed. Only a week later, she bumped into a man on a random sidewalk while she was taking pictures in the city. She only saw him coming when the light glinted off of his hair, a blazing bronze color. She learned, over coffee, that his name was Ermin, but he liked to go by 'Ernie' and that he was a journalist. Soon after, Ernie was offered a gig touring the world and so she packed her things and followed him through countless countries, becoming a renowned

photojournalist herself. They saw—firsthand— death and destruction, loss, and the pure strength of community. They followed soldiers through wars, towns through famine, rebellions and revolutions. They married in Japan, had children in Spain, their first home in Brazil, and yet— despite all their adventures—they settled back into that house Emma grew up in.

Here, they lived out their days until Emma began to grow weak from the same disease that took her mother all those years ago. Surrounded by her three grown children, Ernie, and somewhere, the spirit of her mother, Emma passed in her home, in a hospital bed her husband demanded be brought into their bedroom.

As soon as she closed her eyes for that last time, she fell into darkness, a bitter cold forcing its way around her.



She woke up in warmth, again. Sunlight licked at her face, the branch she perched upon shaking in the breeze. Out on the marsh below her, her flock waded in the brackish water, peeking below the surface for fish and mollusks.

Days must pass with her in this tree. She pecks at the bugs that crawl from their burrows in the branch below her for sustenance but mostly, she just watches the water. This morning, with the sun hanging above her for longer than usual, a booming voice approaches her oasis.

“Here, you’ll see the wood stork, native to our wetlands here in Georgia. Right now, they seem to be feeding.”

A group of people gaggle around the edge of the marsh, binoculars held to their eyes, mouths open.

“Their diet consists of fish, amphibians, insects, and snails. This flock actually was here before this conservation program was, all of them born and raised here, except for the black one you’ll see up in the tree to your right.” The man with the speaker at the front of the group points to her. The group turn their attention fully to her. “She would be our only black stork, typically found in Asia and Europe.”

“Well, then how did she end up here, Ermie?” a child calls from the front of the group. His mother shushes him, ruffling his hair.

Ermie.

She knows that name.

“Good question, kiddo! She was brought to us last year as a rescue from an exotic breeder. Thankfully, the flock took her in as their own. She is not very active compared to the other members of her flock, but she seems to enjoy it here.”

She cocks her head, her long beak sticking out in front of her. She doesn’t remember that.

“We call her Emma.”

The name moves through the crowd as they murmur it. The man smiles and begins to walk backward, waving his hands toward his chest.

“If you’ll follow me, we will move onto our next flock, the Great Egrets.”

The group turns all at once and shuffle after him. She watches them go.

Emma.

She knows that name, too. It sticks to her brain, feeling so familiar yet so unknown.

Her flock startles from a noise far into the woods behind them, flapping into her tree to settle in its branches.

Ermie.

Why does she know that name? Her feet are glued to her branch, her toes gripping the wood.

Emma.

She goes to say it and all that comes out is a discordant noise that begins to echo through the tree, the rest of the flock honking in response.

Ermie.

Before she realizes it, years pass with her sitting in the tree; her flock bringing her bugs and frogs every so often, so she'll feed.

Emma, Emma, Emma.

Tours dwindle in size and frequency throughout these years but with every one, the guide points her out, her oddity in species, habits, and name.

One early walk around the conservation property, one of the guides finds Emma at rest in the mud right below her branch. She alerts the foundation and soon, Emma's story becomes one of past tense. Protocol is to let nature take its course on passed wildlife and so her body grows over with fungi and moss, decaying into the soil. Predators peck on her corpse, prey crawling over it and months later, there is no trace of Emma except for the plaque hammered into the ground in front of the tree that says, *Home to Emma's Branch.*

She floats in that coldness until the last of her tissue and bone are broken into pieces of ammonia for the decomposers to nitrify.



She wakes up in warmth.

Red and yellow leaves shiver from where they sprout from her bark. Rolling hills and green pastures fill her vision, wildflowers and bumblebees swaying with each other. It's quiet out here. The chirps of birds and skitters of squirrels are the only sounds that fill the space.

For decades, she stands mighty from the ground, branches reaching for the sun, seeing nothing of humanity as she grows. One day, when the sun was a little whiter and the air a little cooler, a young man comes along. In his arms he carries a woven basket and a blanket. He throws the gingham print out at her trunk and rifles through the contents of the basket. He sits there for hours, chewing on apple after apple, before packing his things and trekking off. The next week, he returns.

Every week since that very first day, he treks to her base and lays out. She can see him coming from the bottom of the hill she sprouts from by the sheer light that reflects off of his deep yellow hair. Season through season she sees him, always alone. And though they may not communicate, something draws her toward him, and surely, him toward her.

Years upon years upon years into this routine, he doesn't show up for their time together. A month goes by without him and one day a woman with his eyes and bronze hair that burns like fire makes her way to Emma.

At Emma's trunk, she digs a small hole and places a metal urn inside it before covering it with soil. On top of the earth now disturbed, she sticks a cross with the name "Ernie" written on it with a heart.

She sees another century or two, maybe three, of passing day and night and nothing of humanity as she fights storms and frost. On one of her completed travels on the Earth around the sun, a burly man dressed in a flannel cuts her down.



She wakes up in warmth.

She remembers the faint remnants of *something* floating in the back of her mind, *something* telling her this is not all unfamiliar. She can't place the thoughts that swirl in her brain: flashes of a film camera, three children, a man. She can recall the knowledge of something that was before this.

Life, beautiful life and then *nothing*.

She's human again, she knows it.

Right now, she's probably about 11 years old. Things are pretty much the same, except she's in the body of a boy, and his name is Emmanuel. Big curls sprout from her head, just like her mother's. She's bowlegged in this body. There's a permanent gap in her teeth and she puts up with it until she's forced into a dentist's chair. With braces and chest hair, she enters the world of middle school and then high school.

She's different, she knows she is. The other kids know it, too. She finds solace from the spilled lunch trays and sneers in the robotics classroom and soon, she's found a passion.

She grows into her gangly arms and a successful career as an engineer, but never her identity. People call her Emmanuel and though it isn't horrible, it isn't right. The hairs that peek above her upper lip and the sharp angles of her body don't fit her and though she may not know what she looked like in the life before this, she knows it cannot be correct.

She keeps her head down, though, and becomes globally recognized for her work in the field. She discovers theories of the universe and estimates the time they have left on their Earth.

She never marries, never goes out, never treats herself. She has few friends outside of her colleagues.

She dies in her 60s. The doctor will say her body is just overworked, overdone, overdue for rest. Those close to her will know she took her own life.

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She doesn't wake up, this time, but her atoms have been pulverized and pressurized into a compact piece of limestone that's been sliced and diced and poured into someone's driveway. She's kicked around and driven over and picked up by a bird and carried to a tree to make up part of a nest and dropped to the ground when the fledglings took flight. She is tumbled around the Earth, whittling away at every edge until she is powder.

She never entered that cold. She died and simply ceased to be.

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She wakes up in warmth.

It's been a while. She can feel the phantom scratch of gravel against her surface and this feeling of rolling over and over herself but nothing else fills the space between the gun that had been in her hand and what she wakes into now.

She's a star, nestled into the open palm of space. She's bright, maybe the brightest one to yet to be discovered. She can see Earth from her place. It's more brown than green, compared to her studies in previous life.

Over the next thousands of years, she watches how the brown drains into gray and the blue of the oceans turn yellow. Signals pass through her atmosphere, pleas for help and hopes of other lives. Ships launch ad nauseam, passing by to wrap their orbit around her and slingshot from the other side, gaining a boost from her gravitational pull. She doesn't know where they're going.

She begins to drift from her planetly neighbors. It's a slow process, so slow she doesn't realize it until she goes to look at Earth, but space debris and smaller stars that have gathered around her over time block her view—distance between them lengthens with each galactic orbit until she can no longer see them, shrouded by that thick darkness.

Over time, who knows how long, an asteroid emerges from that deep, dark void. Her spin seems to stop as she anticipates its contact on her surface. The closer it gets though, it seems to want to circle her. Eventually, it becomes part of her orbit. It doesn't sling back around to gain momentum. It becomes one with her, a gentle joining, and before she knows it, they pass by supernovas and blackholes, languid, and yet pay them no mind. The asteroid may not have a face or a name, but to her, there's a pull. Something that isn't just a physical gravitation, no. There's a

pull there where she thinks she and this asteroid were meant to become a part of a system together.

They have no choice but to follow the ebb and flow of their universe. They stretch and stretch and stretch and suddenly, they are alone in this never-ending vacuum.

Here, at the edge of the universe, she finds it is very cold. So cold it pierces through her being and into her soul. Her asteroid grows closer, and she finds she doesn't mind if they were to crash into her.

Now, she feels like she's being pulled taut and for a second, she thinks the fabric of time will rip with her. Something races where her chest would be in her earthly body, the cold beginning to rip into her core. It becomes unbearable, this tension, and just before her very quarks tear themselves from each other, it all stops.

This is the end of the universe, surely. This is where it all ends, this cycle of life and of death. The universe is dying right before her.

She collapses in on herself with her asteroid and the trillions of other celestial bodies that crossed to the other side of the universe, everything she knows unraveling, screaming in on each other, ending with a crash so loud everything is quiet.

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She wakes up in warmth.